

Q.3a (20 marks): Formalist and substantivist approaches in economic anthropology

3. (a)

आथक नृवज्ञान क सदभ म रूपवाद आर तत्ववाद दृष्टकाणा का आलाचनात्मक पराक्षण काजए।

Critically discuss the formalist and substantivist approaches in the context of economic anthropology.

20

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Economic Anthropology deals with studying the economy in the social and cultural context.

Malinowski's study of Kula ring exchange among the Trobriand Islanders is considered to be the pioneering work in this field.

Karl Polanyi in his book "Social Transformation" mentioned two different approaches.

- formalist
- substantivist.

① FORMALIST APPROACH

(i) concept → economies of all societies whether simple or advanced can be studied through application of economic laws and principles like

- profit-loss
- principle of maximisation.
- rationality in investment.

(ii) This study can be achieved only through the help of expert economists who are thorough with the economic principles.

(iii) Scholars Associated.

- Raymond Firth
- Henskovitz.
- Schneider

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CRITICISM

- 1) Principle of Profit Maximisation doesn't apply everywhere
eg Kuikuru of Amazon work $3\frac{1}{2}$ hours a day, even if they work for $\frac{1}{2}$ hour more they could attain surplus.
- 2) Sahlins said → "Tribes are optimizers and not maximizers".
- 3) Malinowski showed how Kula-ring exchange had a deeper value in the social and cultural life of Trobrianders.

- 4) Sahlins also quoted → " what Money is to the West, Kinship is to the Rest".

②

SUBSTANTIVIST APPROACH

- (i) Concept → study of economy of simple societies should be undertaken at the deeper social and cultural aspect level.
- (ii) Economy of simple societies is deeply embedded in their respective societies
- (iii) This study can be achieved only through holistic study by an Anthropologist
- (iv) Economic laws and Principles are not always applied in the economy of simple societies.
- (v) Scholars Associated
 - Sahlins and Service
 - Karl Polanyi
 - Malinowski.

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CRITICISM

1) Rationality in economy shown by some simple societies too.

[eg] Eskimos engage in fish trade guided by profit.

2) In Contemporary times → No isolated Society present due to rapid globalization. Therefore simple societies ultimately got influenced by economy of others.

3) Narrows down the economic life of simple societies to their cultural needs only.

Hence, Formalist and substantivist view together provide an holistic approach for economic anthropology.

Welfare Policies through Taxation in modern societies is a good example of the integration of these two approaches.